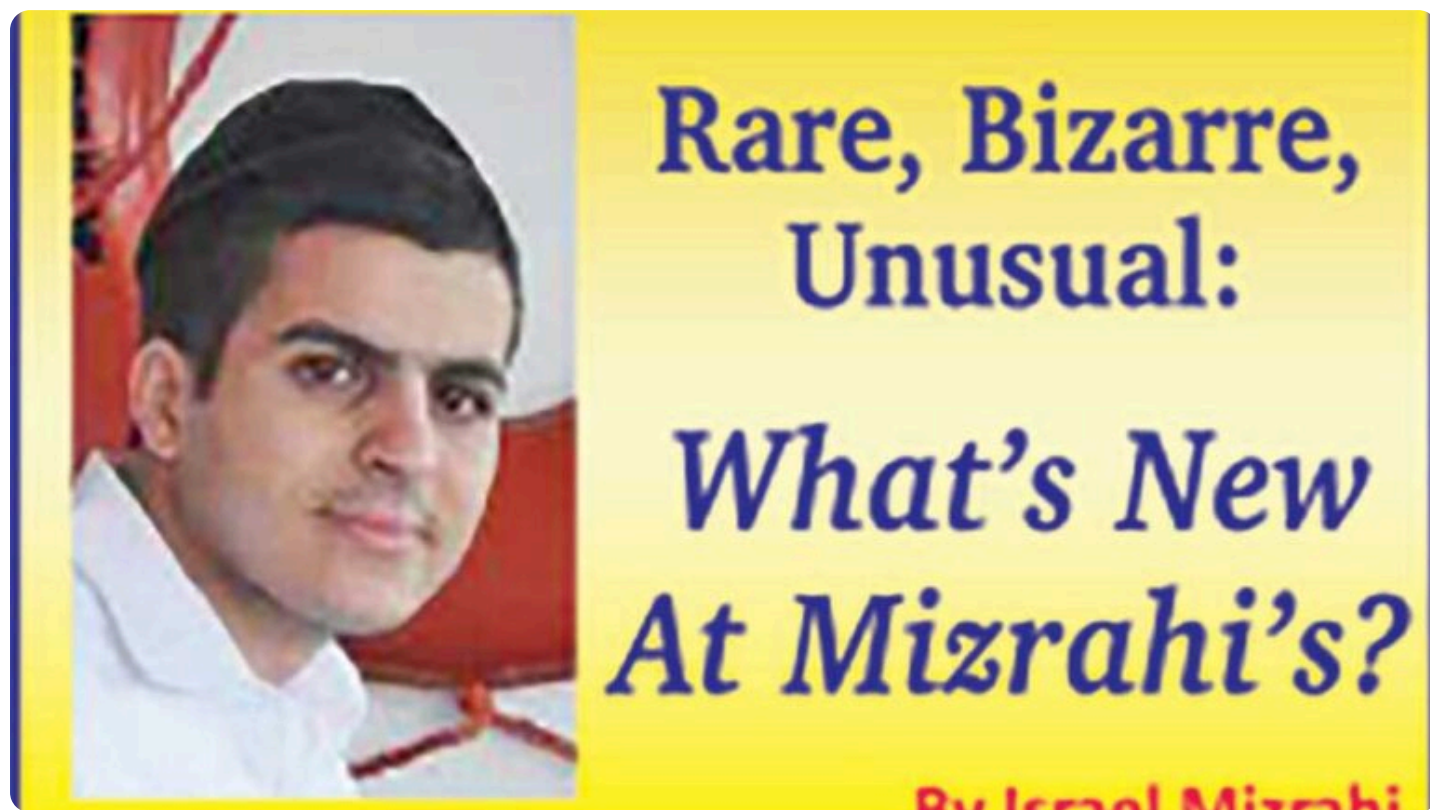


Does Kapparot Have Non-Jewish Origins?

BY ISRAEL MIZRAHI | OCTOBER 10, 2024, 6 PM ET



*K*apparot, a widespread custom practiced by Jewish communities throughout the world, was not always so prevalent. While today, controversy exists regarding the possible cruelty of the chickens that may be involved, the custom on its own is ubiquitous. This week, though, I had obtained several early printed editions of the *Shulchan Aruch* that tell a different story.

There is mention of the custom of *kapparot* already in the 7th century, but even then, the source we have states the reason for this custom is unknown. Over the next centuries, the custom spread, particularly in Europe. R. Yosef Karo finished writing the *Shulchan Aruch* in 1563, in Safed, Eretz Yisrael. The first edition, was printed by the author in Venice, in 1565. In *siman* 605, discussing the customs relating to Yom Kippur, the heading states that the custom of *kapparot* is nonsensical. In the body of the text, R. Yosef Karo goes on to write that it is an imperative to prevent the practice of this custom. This is based on the opinions of the Ramban, Rashba and others, who reason with suspicion that the custom has non-Jewish origins. The Rema, though, in his glosses to the *Shulchan Aruch*, published in editions from 1570 and on, upheld the custom and wrote that it was customary in his communities. For the first score of editions, this heading and statement of the *Shulchan Aruch* was printed in every edition.

In 1708, an edition published in Amsterdam revised the heading to a neutral text, titling the *siman* as "*The custom of kapparot on Erev Yom Kippur*." Within a few years, this revision became permanent, present in nearly every subsequent edition until today.